



Rites and Spiritual Duties for Deacons

Deacon Service Guide

"When I look at the deacons in their white garments, I feel as though I am looking at the angels of heaven praising before the throne." - Saint John Chrysostom

The Church arranges the deacons in two opposing rows facing one another, unlike the congregation, who stand facing east.

We ascend from the nave of the church to the deacons' chorus because the deacons resemble the ranks of angels surrounding the throne of God, clothed in their white tunics and wearing their stoles like wings. From the chorus, we ascend again to enter the sanctuary, which resembles the throne of God. The following are the rules, rites and spiritual duties that every deacon must observe with care, so that he may be worthy of this service and become a true image of a servant of God.

SPIRITUAL FORMATION AND CHARACTER

- 1. Study the Coptic language.** Every deacon, regardless of rank, should learn Coptic because it is central to the Church's rites, readings, hymns and praises. Where possible, learn to read the Coptic script rather than relying only on transliteration.
- 2. Learn and continually practice the hymns.** Hymns and responses should be studied carefully, revised regularly and offered accurately and prayerfully.
- 3. Learn through discipleship.** Learn hymns, rites and service under the guidance of a capable and experienced deacon or hymnist.
- 4. Participate faithfully in the worship of the Church.** Take an active part in the Divine Liturgies, Vespers and Midnight Praises (Tasbeha), not only on the days you are rostered.
- 5. Maintain a regular life of confession and Holy Communion.** Every deacon should have a father of confession, confess regularly, and receive Holy Communion when serving, according to the guidance of his priest and father of confession.
- 6. Grow in the knowledge of the Church.** Study the Holy Bible, Church doctrine, rites, hymns, spiritual teaching and the life of the Church - not only responses and ritual details.
- 7. Serve beyond the chorus.** Participate in other spiritual ministries such as Sunday School, youth, Bible study and parish service. A deacon is a servant filled with the Holy Spirit, wisdom and knowledge, not merely someone who recites responses.
- 8. Live the scriptural character of a deacon.** Reverence, truthfulness, self-control, purity of conscience, faithfulness and good order in the home should be visible in every deacon.
1 Timothy 3:8, 13: *"Likewise deacons must be reverent, not double-tongued, not given to much wine, not greedy for money ... For those who have served well as deacons obtain for themselves a good standing and great boldness in the faith which is in Christ Jesus."*
- 9. Guard your tongue.** Avoid cursing, swearing, lying and gossip. The same mouth that praises God should not be used to wound others.
James 3:10: *"Out of the same mouth proceed blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not to be so."*
- 10. Do not become a stumbling block.** A deacon must not smoke, drink alcohol, or behave in a way that damages his witness or becomes an obstacle to others.
- 11. Treat fellow deacons with love.** Do not compete, dominate, rival, step over, insult or mistreat another deacon. Service is not a contest; the chorus should be marked by brotherly love and cooperation.
- 12. Accept correction and spiritual discipline with humility.** If a priest gives a corrective instruction or a period of repentance, receive it with obedience and without complaint or pride, learning through it the value and spirituality of service.

ARRIVAL, VESTING AND HOLY COMMUNION

- 13. Arrive early for the Divine Liturgy.** A deacon who arrives after the Absolution of the Servants is not to vest or serve. If he arrives after the Liturgy Gospel, he should not receive Holy Communion unless he first receives absolution and permission from the priest.
- 14. Wear the tunic whenever serving.** Deacons serving in the chorus, and especially inside the sanctuary, must be properly vested – vestments should be clean, neatly ironed, well maintained and treated with care and reverence.
- 15. Present the tunic and stole to the priest for blessing before vesting.**

The blessing expresses:

- a. Permission to serve in the Divine Liturgy.

- b. Recognition that the deacon remains in good standing under the discipline of the Church.
- c. Permission to partake of the Holy Mysteries.
- d. The deacon's obedience and submission to the priestly order:
"the lesser is blessed by the better" (Hebrews 7:7).

16. Receive the blessing reverently. Hold the tunic and stole, bow the head or kneel, and receive the priest's sign of the cross and blessing with humility.

17. After the blessing, kiss the cross and the priest's hand. Then say with humility: "I have sinned, absolve me."

18. Wear the stole correctly according to your rank. Follow the traditional arrangement for your rank:

- a. Psaltos (Cantor): wears the tunic without a stole.
- b. Ognostis (Reader): wears the stole crossing over the left shoulder and around the waist as a belt, with the ends hanging from the shoulders; on the back it forms a cross and resembles angelic wings.
- c. Epideacon / Assistant Deacon (Subdeacon): wears the stole in the same manner as the Ognostis, crossed over the shoulder and bound around the waist as a belt.
- d. Deacon / Archdeacon: wears the stole hanging on the left shoulder, symbolising carrying the cross; the ends resemble the wings of angels.

19. Pray while putting on the vestments. Begin the appointed psalms as you vest: Psalm 29, "*I will exalt You, O Lord...*" and Psalm 92, "*The Lord reigns, He is clothed with majesty...*"

20. Do not wear the tunic as ordinary clothing. The tunic is reserved for the service of the Church and should not be worn casually outside its proper liturgical use.

21. Do not remove the tunic before the service is properly concluded. Remain vested until the end of the Liturgy and the dismissal of the Angel of the Sacrifice, unless the priest directs otherwise for a genuine reason.

22. Pray while removing the vestments. As you take off the service vestments, begin Psalm 47: "*O clap your hands, all you people!...*"

23. A deacon who has vested and served should receive Holy Communion. It is not appropriate to vest and serve and then choose not to receive Communion, unless there is a genuine reason discussed with the priest or father of confession.

24. Give fellow deacons the opportunity to receive Holy Communion. During the distribution of the Holy Mysteries, chorus deacons should alternate their service so each deacon can receive reverently.

ORDER OF SERVICE IN THE DIVINE LITURGY

25. Hold candles at the appointed liturgical moments. Deacons should hold candles with reverence:

- a. During the selection of the Lamb until the chosen Lamb is placed on the paten and the wine is placed in the chalice.
- b. During the reading of the Liturgy Gospel.
- c. During the Institution Narrative.
- d. During the Fraction.
- e. Before the Mysteries during Holy Communion.

26. Do not distract the congregation with the censer. After the commemoration of the saints, do not carry a censer full of incense among the congregation in a way that distracts people from prayer and attention to the sacrifice on the altar.

27. Keep silence and order during the Liturgy. Do not talk unnecessarily with other deacons or repeatedly enter and leave the sanctuary without a genuine reason.

28. The deacon service must have clear leadership. The highest-ranked and most experienced deacon appointed for the service is responsible for keeping order, allocating readings, arranging responses and coordinating the chorus under the direction of the priest.

29. Organise the service inside the sanctuary carefully. According to the church's arrangement, the senior deacon may assist the serving priest and follow the liturgy book, while another deacon prepares the censer and the names of the departed. All roles are carried out under the priest's direction.

30. Hold a regular deacons' meeting. Meet to study the Bible, Church rites, doctrine, hymns, spiritual matters and the Coptic language; allocate Coptic, English and Arabic readings; and prepare an organised roster for service inside and outside the sanctuary.

31. Respect the roster and your turn of service. A deacon who is absent, arrives late or does not vest for his assigned service may lose that turn and wait until his next rostered opportunity. If unable to attend, give at least one day's notice wherever possible so the service can be reassigned.

32. Allocate feast readings and visible duties fairly. Special readings and duties such as carrying the cross or icon should be entrusted fairly, with faithfulness and regular attendance taken into account, so feast-day service remains a blessing and never becomes a source of rivalry.

33. Sing and respond as one chorus. Responses and hymns should be offered in one united voice under the guidance of the senior or lead deacon, not as competing individual performances.

34. Do not show off your voice. Responses, hymns and readings are prayers, not performances. Serve with reverence, humility and attention to the congregation's prayer.

35. Serve according to your rank. Know and follow the responsibilities and limits of your rank, including the correct wearing of the stole, permitted readings and service inside and outside the sanctuary.

36. Maintain the traditional order of the deacon chorus. Deacons outside the sanctuary should serve from the appointed north and south choruses, standing in the place assigned by the senior deacon. The chorus should be orderly and attentive while the congregation faces east toward the altar.

REVERENCE INSIDE AND AROUND THE SANCTUARY

37. Enter and leave the sanctuary with reverence. Use the side entrances rather than the central priestly entrance, except where the rite specifically requires otherwise, such as the Litany of the Gospel. Enter with the right foot first and leave carefully with the left foot first while maintaining reverence toward the altar.

38. Move around the altar in the prescribed direction. Follow the church's established movement around the altar and do not wander or cross unnecessarily.

39. Do not cross unnecessarily in front of the altar. Avoid obscuring the congregation's view of the altar. Use the side entrances and move quietly and purposefully.

40. Avoid greetings inside the sanctuary. The sanctuary is a place of prayer and attention to Christ and the sacrifice. Do not turn the service into a place for social greetings or distracting conversation.

Deacons serving in the altar should remain in peace and unity, remembering that *"as we stand in Your Holy Altar, we are considered to be standing in heaven."* Greeting and unnecessary interaction can create disturbance within the altar, causing distraction from Christ and the Holy Sacrifice. All deacons should therefore remain reverent, attentive and prayerful.

41. Remain prayerful until the entire service is dismissed. Do not remove the tunic, put shoes back on, leave the church, chat with others, or become occupied with the canteen, Korban or the bookshop before the priest dismisses the Angel of the Sacrifice, except with the priest's permission for a genuine need.

42. The senior deacon must protect the peace and order of the service. He should arrange positions, readings and duties clearly, correct disorder calmly, and help every deacon serve according to rank, ability and the needs of the Liturgy.

43. Take these duties seriously. The purpose of every rule is not outward control but faithful service offered to God: *"My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me, and to finish His work"* (John 4:34).

44. Let every service be a blessing and never an obstacle. Priests, senior deacons and the whole chorus should work together so the prayers are offered with reverence, order and love, and every deacon grows in humility and faithfulness.

May God grant every deacon understanding of his ritual and spiritual duties, humility in service, love for his brothers and faithfulness before the altar. May our service always be a blessing and never an obstacle, and may God lead us according to His will.

Glory, honour and worship be to God forever. Amen.